



semifinals through a draw of lots.

Following the quarterfinals and semifinals in the main city, the action shifted to the outskirts. **The dry heat of Gahunje, compounded by its remote location, made conditions challenging for players and spectators alike.**

Dehydration loomed large, with tender coconut husks scattered around the dugouts, and players battling exhaustion under the blazing sun. Officials and players had to make refreshment arrangements in bulk to power through the conditions.

South encountered additional hurdles, with a team-wide illness and players like Arundhati Reddy requiring medical attention. Similarly, Titas struggled with a persistent cough.

"Day matches have a lot of value as it builds stamina and builds a habit of playing for a longer duration of time," Umesh Sethi, the East Zone coach, tells *Sportstar* on the sidelines.

"That said, I hope these fixtures are scheduled for the winter. If it's a one-day fixture, it's fine to play in such trying conditions, but in summer, these games are hard on

Triumphant: East Zone, which won the inter-zonal multi-day trophy.

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the body and on the surface.

Sethi feels the quality of the game will improve if it is played in winter. "The pitch doesn't get time to get prepared properly, and on the second day itself, it dries out and then ends up costing the side that has won the toss. In this game, we wanted to win the toss and bat. We were very happy to dismiss the opponent for a modest score, but the pitch cracked up on day two. It made life difficult for us as well, and we couldn't take the lead. If we do these fixtures in winter, the surface won't break down so much," Sethi adds.

East Zone captain Deepti Sharma was awarded the winner's cheque of Rs. 50 lakh. Former India captain and BCCI Apex Council member, Shubhangi Kulkarni, watched the game from the Members' Box in the South End and presented the winner's trophy. This added a special significance to the event, as Pune held sentimental value in Kulkarni's crickering career.

In perspective

"I was lucky to be in a place like Pune, which has been very progressive and safe for women," she tells *Sportstar*. "Those days, a career in cricket came with a lot of apprehension — be it for safety, be it women playing what was considered a men's game. When we played, we always had people come and watch. It began with curiosity about our attire — whether we would turn up in trousers, salwars, or skirts. We played in trousers, of course. Once that initial curiosity was satiated, the support was steady and more game-focused."

Shubhangi comes from an era when Test cricket was the main format, with one-day cricket gradually gaining prominence.

"Our domestic cricket was mostly in the one-day format. But the semifinals of the Inter-State competition called the Nationals then, would be a two-day affair, and the final would be a three-day